CHAPTER EIGHT

SEAFARING COMMUNITIES, 1800–1850

Brian Rouleau

In 1849, no less an authority than Herman Melville reflected upon the sailor's instrumentality to the Atlantic world. Himself a seaman before moving on to write memorable maritime novels such as *Moby Dick* and *Billy Budd*, Melville could speak from experience as he sketched out what it meant to be a waterborne worker. Seafarers, in his estimation, were 'the true importers, and exporters of spices and silks; of fruits and wines and marbles; they carry missionaries, ambassadors, opera-singers, armies, merchants, tourists, [and] scholars to their destination;' they acted as 'a bridge of boats across the Atlantic' and were, fundamentally, the '*primum mobile* of all commerce.' If they suddenly disappeared, he reminded his readers, 'almost everything would stop here on earth.' Yet the centrality of seamen to the basic functioning of Atlantic exchange systems, Melville concluded, was easily overlooked. For, the author asked, 'what are sailors?' 'What in your heart do you think of the fellow staggering along the dock?' These were, ultimately, men 'deemed almost the refuse and offscourings of the earth.' Seafaring communities crucial to the daily lives of millions around the Atlantic, Melville complained, were hidden in plain sight.[1]

That paradox – of the central and yet largely overlooked role seafarers played within the broader nineteenth-century Atlantic world – remains the focus of this essay. We know a great deal about the circulation of goods, peoples, and knowledge which comprises Atlantic history, and yet, the sailors who moved those items, individuals, and ideas are often ignored or taken for granted. There are many possible explanations for our selective amnesia regarding the waterborne world, but the most significant factor is almost certainly the strange disciplinary divides which still insist on treating sailors as a distinct class of people worthy of separate inquiry. In the words of one early American maritime historian, 'the sailor lives in a little world of his own,' and 'is like the inhabitants of some undiscovered country.' As that attitude became consensus opinion, seafaring communities were often studied as discrete and bounded entities unto themselves, almost entirely cut off from the world which surrounded them. This insistence upon sailor isolation was ironic, though, given the influential role mariners played in weaving together the disparate threads of the Atlantic basin. Even a cursory glance at the early nineteenth-century maritime world

belies claims about the sailor's relative isolation, and forces us to concede that seafaring communities have long been at the center of the Atlantic world.[2]

REVOLUTIONARY BEGINNINGS

One defining moment for transatlantic seafaring communities was the era of revolutionary upheaval initiated by the American war for independence. A top down history of that conflict has gentlemen assembled in Philadelphia to draft declarations and coordinate a united colonial response to the supposed tyranny of British policy. Examining events leading up to (and during) the formal break between Great Britain and thirteen North American colonies from the bottom up, however, situates sailors in the thick of anti-imperial protest. The American Revolution, in a very real sense, began on the waterfront. It was mariners, after all, who were deeply affected by interruptions in trade instigated by Parliament's attempts to more stringently police colonial commerce after the Seven Years' War. Many sailors made up the mob of irate Bostonians – a 'motley rabble of saucy boys, Negroes, mulattoes, Irish teagues and outlandish Jack Tars,' in John Adams' disapproving words – fired upon by British soldiers during the infamous 'massacre' of 1770. And seafarers more generally turned out en masse to protest the practice of impressment, wherein the Royal Navy, to replenish its ranks, seized subjects from port cities and forced them into service aboard ships of war.[3]

Impressment was itself a truly Atlantic practice, given the British navy's size, dominance, and omnipresence. But, if experience with the press gang united disparate seaside communities throughout the region, so did the politics and tactics of anti-impressment. Imperious naval officers seeking to forcibly recruit seamen often ran up against the determined resistance of mariners and local populations willing to lose neither friends and relatives nor the value of their labor. The press was a threat to personal liberty, but bad for business as well, given the commercial disruptions resulting from the extraction of men from merchant vessels. Prior to the American Revolution, therefore, several sizeable anti-impressment riots rocked both colonial seaports and British cities. And many sailors were in the vanguard of the independence movement exactly because it would – at least in theory – put an end to the experience of servitude aboard His Majesty's ships. Liberty, at times an abstract concept for the nation's founders, had more immediate meaning for people subject to involuntary work under arduous conditions. Seafaring communities throughout America therefore saw much to gain from political separation with Britain, and threw themselves into the effort.[4]

When Thomas Jefferson inserted impressment into the Declaration of Independence's list of grievances against George III, he merely ratified what was already popular sentiment along the waterfront. Indeed, anti-impressment was *the* source of politicization for plebian peoples (not simply sailors, but many other of the harbor's denizens as well) during the revolutionary era, and it is nearly impossible to overstress the pervasive climate of fear and resentment produced by the regularity of capture and forced labor. The arm of the imperial state, in other words, often fell most forcefully on seafaring communities. Sailors' violent resistance, meanwhile, pushed others less inclined to act closer to rebellion. Hence one patriot's assessment that the uprising against the crown had been precipitated by seamen, fishermen, and

harbor workers: 'an army of furious men, whose actions are all animated by a spirit of vengeance and hatred against the English, who had destroyed their livelihood and the liberty of their country.'[5]

At times during the revolutionary struggle, allegiances could be fickle and survival often depended upon flexible loyalty – mariner John Blatchford's chronicle of the revolutionary Atlantic spoke of repeated capture and re-capture by British and American authorities on the high seas – but a high percentage of now self-consciously American seamen remained loyal to the patriot cause despite inducements offered by their British captors. By the end of the war many sailors proudly spoke of their centrality to the struggle for independence. Iconography and memorialization of the conflict in the United States, moreover, often valorized the contributions and heroic sacrifices of seamen. In a new democratic republic nominally devoted to the advancement of ordinary people, common sailors stood as potent symbols. Maritime issues, moreover, continued to percolate throughout public discussion of the new nation's place within the wider Atlantic world.[6]

'BRAVE REPUBLICANS OF THE OCEAN'

With independence secured by 1783, the new United States was now free to crawl out from under the restrictive legislation which had sought to confine colonial trade within the boundaries of the British empire. American ships began to fan out across the globe, reaching as far as China within a few short years of the Revolution's conclusion. But this new-found liberty to traffic with the world carried with it certain dangers. The most pressing of these was the absence of the Royal Navy's protection. Previously, ships departing North America could rely on military escort. The young republic's ships, on the other hand, were potential prey for both marauders and rival maritime states. Waters around North Africa proved especially troubling, given the prevalence of piratical powers. Those societies' ruling classes made their money extracting tribute from foreign governments in exchange for safe passage through the Mediterranean. Nations which could or would not pay, on the other hand, were considered fair game for plundering. Captured crews, meanwhile, were often brought ashore and sold into slavery unless ransomed.[7]

By 1784, an American vessel had been seized by a Moroccan raider, with Algerian, Tripolitan, and Tunisian pirates quick to follow suit, oftentimes with the encouragement of British officials eager to exact vengeance against their former dependents. The United States paid tribute and spent money to free hostages when it could, but these expenditures at times represented over one-sixth of the young nation's budget, and quickly overwhelmed the treasury. The number of captive sailors, meanwhile, continued to grow. Generally confined to port cities, enslaved seamen were set to work on chain gangs constructing roads and fortifications, while those with artisanal skills saw service as forcibly enlisted blacksmiths or carpenters. But the men were also objects of public fascination at home in the United States. Redeemed captives wrote narratives detailing their suffering, popular plays were performed describing the experience of Barbary captivity, and port-city subscriptions raised money to alleviate their suffering. Much of the Barbary literature, moreover, became a roundabout way of publicly discussing the contradictions posed by slavery within the United States itself. Abolitionists wondered how 'Turkish' slavery could horrify Americans, given

the nation's own population of unfree laborers. In what would become a trend across the early nineteenth century, seafaring communities were enlisted to examine and discuss some of the larger problems plaguing American society. The maritime world often tested the definition and limits of national sovereignty, not to mention the very meaning of 'liberty' itself. Sailors heavily publicized their many miseries abroad, and drove a larger conversation about the implications of independence. Was the nation truly sovereign if it allowed its 'brave republicans of the ocean' (a term many American sailors used to refer to themselves) to remain suffering captives abroad? How could a country for which mariners had sacrificed abandon them?[8]

That question became all the more urgent as the British continued the practice of impressment. With Napoleon's rise to power and France's strengthening position on the European continent, Great Britain looked to its naval supremacy as a key bulwark. But, chronic manpower shortages prolonged the Royal Navy's dependence upon the abduction of seafarers. The United States, which pursued an official policy of neutrality in what was considered a European affair, nevertheless found itself repeatedly drawn into the conflict. This was largely the result of maritime actors. American merchants (and a federal government almost entirely dependent upon customs receipts for its basic solvency) expected to profit from the wars of the French Revolution by acting as a carrier for belligerent powers. Essential food and other commodities could be transshipped by U.S.-flagged vessels, allowing the republic to flourish even as monarchical Europe imploded. Of course, the exercise of neutral rights requires that states at war respect those rights, and this was something the British in particular were not inclined to do.

Britain's infamous 'Orders in Council' granted the country's naval personnel the right to board nominally neutral shipping, impress alleged subjects found aboard, and interdict any goods thought potentially beneficial to an enemy power's war effort. The British justified their behavior as that which was necessary to preserve liberty throughout the Atlantic basin, threatened as it supposedly was by Napoleonic tyranny. And moreover, they rejected American claims that mariners naturalized as U.S. citizens were immune from naval seizure. Rather, British authorities subscribed to the idea of indefeasible allegiance, which is to say, once a subject of the crown, always a subject. The figures remain imprecise, but it is believed that between 1803 and 1812, between six and eight thousand sailors were forcibly removed from American ships. Relations between the United States and Great Britain deteriorated all the more rapidly after the Royal Navy began to target even ships afloat in American territorial waters. The most notorious of these episodes saw HMS *Leopard* open fire on USS *Chesapeake* outside of Norfolk, Virginia. Three American sailors were killed outright, while another four were stolen out of the damaged ship. Public demonstrations of outrage spread throughout the country, with seafaring communities again at the center of a maelstrom. Seafarers led the charge in agitating for punitive measures, and once again, waterfront districts proved themselves among the most politically active and highly radicalized spaces within the Atlantic world.[9]

The rallying cry which ultimately resulted in an American declaration of war was 'Free Trade and Sailors' Rights.' Emblazoned on a banner flown by American naval war hero Captain David Porter, the slogan was intended as a defiant display meant to rally seamen and goad adversaries. Yet each half of that singular equation possessed a history prior to the 1812 conflict with Britain which made American citizens

particularly receptive to it as a rationale for combat. 'Free trade' was an elastic term possessed of multiple meanings. But, at some basic level, it expressed hostility to the then-reigning paradigm of mercantilism, with its emphasis on protectionist policy meant to enrich individual empires and cripple rival states. American revolutionaries had imagined themselves rebelling against such antiquated policies and ushering in a new era of international relations rooted in the free and peaceful exchange of goods on seas open to the ships of all nations. 'Sailors' rights,' on the other hand, possessed a more plebeian meaning. It spoke to a long tradition of popular resistance to impressment. When combined, the concepts proved a potent justification for the War of 1812 with Great Britain, a war fought largely over what Americans saw as

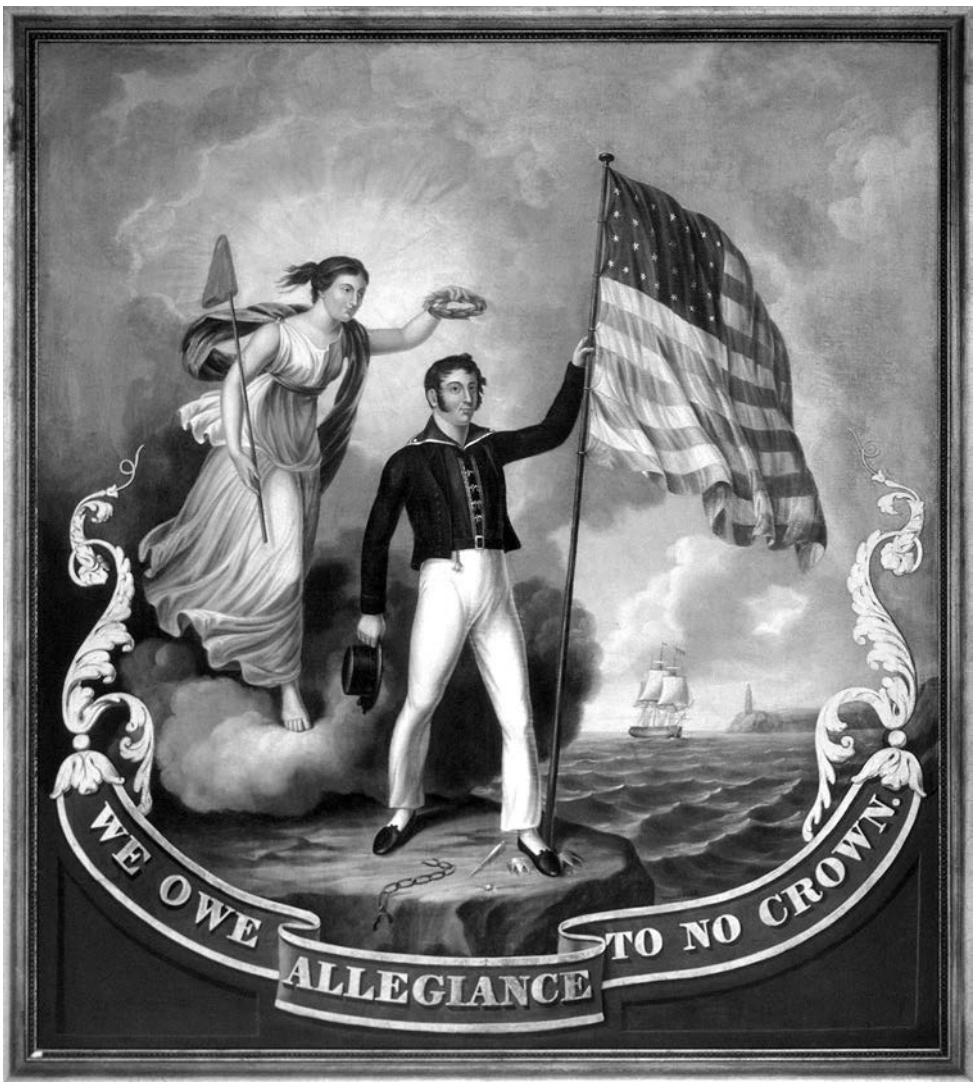

Figure 8.1 John Archibald Woodside's painting, entitled: We Owe Allegiance to No Crown © 2014 Photo National Portrait Gallery, Smithsonian/Art Resource/Scala, Florence

repeated violations of their sovereignty on the high seas. The fighting itself remained inconclusive and the 1814 treaty ending hostilities settled nothing; the belligerent powers merely agreed to resume the *status quo antebellum*. But, with the decisive defeat of Napoleon, the British war machine was rapidly disassembled, thus ending impressment and interdiction. Seafaring communities in the United States of course elected to see the war as one fought for their interests, and a conflict in which their contributions effectively allowed the republic to win a 'second independence' from an oppressive foe. America, many of its sailors insisted, would not become a mere client state to its former overlord. Popular iconography during the war often pictured American sailors, swaddled in the flag, proclaiming 'We Owe Allegiance to No Crown.' European powers, in other words, had no right to treat the nation's citizens – and particularly its sailors – as subjects. The War of 1812, while divisive at home, and often disastrous at the battlefront, seemed to have established that principle, if little else. And yet, for those who remained in power at the end of the era's many wars of revolution, the politicized waterfront looked dangerous.[10]

CONTAINING THE CONTAGION OF RADICALISM

In one sense, Atlantic seafaring communities settled down after 1815. The chaos of war and revolution had been contained by the forces of reaction, and an efflorescence of transoceanic trade was the result. But important changes were nevertheless afoot throughout the region. Counterrevolutionary forces had, in the space of a few decades, borne witness to the role of maritime workers in circulating seemingly 'dangerous' ideologies. In response, there was a concerted, state-driven effort to curtail what powerbrokers saw as the seafaring sector's worst tendencies. The revolutionary potential of plebeian radicalism along the waterfront had been useful during the struggle for American independence, and sailor grievances had helped mobilize vast constituencies in subsequent Atlantic conflicts designed to make watery highways safe for national commerce. But some people clearly worried that the insurrectionary potential of maritime workers could be put to far more unwholesome ends.

Hints of these efforts at stymieing the saltwater powder keg were apparent by the early eighteenth century at least. The British state took the lead in suppressing piracy throughout the Atlantic world, given the threat to mercantile interests such sea-robbers represented. The quest to contain piracy was ironic, to some extent, given that England itself had helped create the problem by issuing copious letters of marque authorizing the plunder of Spanish treasure ships. Privateers without enemy targets, it turns out, would begin to turn on their former masters, and the problem soon required a solution before ceaseless marauding and skyrocketing insurance rates made transatlantic commercial enterprise entirely unprofitable. But buccaneers were more than a military threat to the secure conduct of trade. Many pirates were notable for their democratic and egalitarian practices – the election of officers and sharing of wealth – within a maritime world where shipboard norms tended toward hierarchy and authoritarianism. Piracy should not, of course, be confused with utopian socialism. Their brutality often replicated the very state-sanctioned violence they claimed to rebel against, while many more pirates reinforced the Atlantic world's worst human rights violations by trafficking in slaves and plantation-based commodities. And yet, the existential threat pirates represented to the intertwined interests of mercantile capitalism and the nation-

state was taken seriously. No expense was spared in exterminating seaborne raiders, whose often gruesome executions stood as very public warnings to any who might wish to imitate their crimes.[11]

The seagoing community showed itself disposed to other forms of labor radicalism as well. Perhaps not as drastic or dramatic as piracy, efforts at shipboard combination and organization still appeared dangerous enough to warrant violent response on the part of the maritime state. There is no better example of this than the spring 1797 mutinies aboard Royal Navy vessels anchored at Spithead and the Nore. The complaints centered on low wages and abuse by certain unpopular officers, and sailors organized a fleet-wide 'floating republic' of elected delegates to negotiate with officials and maintain discipline within their own ranks. Sailors couched their grievances in patriotic language, and promised to return to duty should an invading French force appear. The Admiralty settled the Spithead dispute peacefully, but when mutineers at the Nore began to blockade London and issue demands for the dissolution of Parliament and immediate peace, authorities took a harder line. The principal ringleaders were captured and executed, with many more sentenced to penal colonies or flogging. Though ultimately suppressed, episodes such as these are instructive for their involvement with the etymology of the term 'strike.' Mariners who crippled their ships by striking (or lowering) the sails made serious contributions to the origins of collective labor action.[12]

In the United States, the potentially subversive qualities of seafaring communities often revolved around the issue of race. Black sailors, in fact, were viewed by slaveholding interests as a potential conduit for abolitionist agitation. There was certainly precedent for believing as much. The Haitian Revolution was a particularly crucial flashpoint in the creation of African-American communication networks spreading news of slave insurrection throughout the West Indies and U.S. South. One historian, for example, has traced the life of Newport Bowers, an African-American mariner constantly on the move from Boston to Baltimore and St. Domingue, and at the latter location acting as an intermediary between ships and shore while assisting escaped slaves. More generally, black sailors and waterfront workers combined with Haitian refugees to circulate rumor and information regarding uprisings, often inspiring imitators elsewhere. Denmark Vesey, in Charleston, South Carolina was one such individual. His life as a free black laborer (and former Haitian slave) in a southern port city placed him in a prime position to act as intermediary between West Indian radicalism and American plantation laborers. During his 1822 trial for allegedly masterminding a slave insurrection, it came out that Vesey was in contact, through the aegis of mariners, with revolutionaries in Haiti. Hence the fears many slaveholders harbored regarding the insurrectionary potential of maritime communication networks. Black sailors, in a general sense, set dangerous examples of mobility and freedom for plantation slaves. But local black maritime workers – enslaved and free river pilots and watermen – were also notorious conduits for the spread of news and anti-slavery literature from harborside to outlying countryside, as well as agents of the underground railroad helping to sneak escaped slaves aboard ships bound north. The many complaints of slaveowners about African-American mariners are revealing; the *Wilmington Aurora*, for example, editorialized that black sailors 'are of course, all of them, from the very nature of their position, abolitionists, and have the best opportunity to inculcate the slaves with their notions of freedom and liberty.[13]

There were, in fact, long-standing patterns within black communities around the Atlantic of seeing seafaring as an opportunity to escape some of the worst injustices of landward life. As romantic nationalism intertwined with racism to harden prejudices ashore, life afloat presented some amelioration; the barbaric Middle Passage, in other words, was not the only way by which peoples of African descent experienced the ocean. By 1820, some estimates place the number of black sailors at something close to 20 percent of the Anglo-American maritime workforce. Most of these individuals served as cooks, stewards, and other lower-status positions aboard ship, though a smaller (but significant) number rose to places of influence and authority as officers and river pilots. As these men found, the ordered and hierarchical nature of shipboard society tended to downplay the significance of race. Vessels required cooperative endeavor on the part of their inhabitants, and black sailors often worked as equals alongside white shipmates, thus experiencing a degree of racial tolerance and harmony not often found on shore. Seafaring labor also provided geographic mobility, allowing black sailors to travel to places beyond their immediate horizon, sometimes experience better treatment elsewhere, and even participate in events thought momentous in the advancement of their particular race. The floating world was, of course, no paradise, and black sailors could be subjected to indignities and humiliations no different than what they were accustomed to within segregated societies at home. This was particularly true as the nineteenth century progressed and nonwhite seamen began to fill more and more of the shipping industry's most menial positions. But, on the whole, black mariners saw shipboard labor as a reliable source of wages, which in turn offered opportunities for advancement and upward social mobility uncommon for most other people of their color within the Atlantic world. Free black communities throughout the area were often anchored by their relatively prosperous seagoing members. Given those circumstances, it makes sense that Maryland slave Frederick Douglass could refer to sailing ships plying the Chesapeake Bay as 'freedom's swift-winged angels, that fly round the world.' 'I am confined in bands of iron,' he complained, but 'O that I were free! O, that that I were on one of your gallant decks, and under your protecting wing!' Tellingly, the famed abolitionist later escaped bondage dressed as a mariner and carrying a seaman's protection certificate provided by a free black sailor from the North.[14]

Such a state of affairs was of course, from the perspective of slaveholders, unacceptable. It was only further evidence of the seafaring community's fundamental subversiveness, and, just as authorities in England had moved against insurgent strikers, so would masters act to crush this menace to slavery. And so, in response to the threats posed by the polyglot maritime world, South Carolina in 1822 passed a Negro Seamen Act. That law was, in turn, swiftly replicated by other southern legislatures. Collectively, these regulations required the detention of all black sailors aboard ships in slaveholding ports. Nonwhite seamen were arrested, marched ashore, and imprisoned until their vessel's departure, with ship captains responsible for the posting of a bond meant to subsidize incarceration. Northern merchants complained of the immense inconvenience and expense such a policy presented, while Britain and France lodged formal diplomatic complaint about their free citizens of color being unlawfully detained by American authorities. But legal challenges to the laws were turned back. Southern jurists argued that the Negro Seamen Acts were no different than the laws which governed black life in the North. If Yankee states could prevent

African Americans from voting, segregate them in public accommodations, and prevent their intermarriage with white people, then what prevented slaveholders from enacting their own restrictions? More pressingly, the law's champions argued that just as the basic right of self-preservation granted states the authority to enact quarantines against sick people to avoid epidemics, so could that same impulse allow for the quarantine of people who might spread the 'contagion' of slave insurrection. For in southern ports, one of the Seamen's Acts' apologists argued, 'we think the presence of a free negro, fresh from the lectures of an Abolition Society equally dangerous' as any other traveler carrying some communicable tropical malady. The laws withstood efforts to overturn them, and represented further challenge to the relatively unrestricted border-crossing which had characterized an earlier Atlantic world. Class and race began to exercise far greater control over the lives of seafaring communities previously insulated, more or less, from those divisive ideologies.[15]

Thus currents of resistance and revolution which subverted the status quo circulated the Atlantic, but these were, at the same time, routes along which repression traveled. The variety of 'racial quarantine' practiced by southern U.S. states was one component of a broader transoceanic effort. These restrictions were crafted in response to exactly the sort of insurgent impulses the seafaring community helped transmit. In Great Britain, for example, Parliament passed the Merchant Shipping Act of 1823. It was a law designed to deal with the island's own 'racial contagion,' represented by so-called Lascar (or South Asian) seamen shipped to English ports aboard East India Company vessels. According to the bill's terms, Lascar sailors were, while in Britain, to be housed within their own segregated facilities. And, those who did not return home aboard their vessels could be arrested, charged with vagrancy, and imprisoned. Meanwhile, the British colony of Sierra Leone was conceptualized, at least in part, as a dumping ground for black seamen mustered out of the Royal Navy – but unwanted on the streets of London – during the massive demobilizations sweeping Europe after Napoleon's defeat. These laws were all rationalized as efforts to strengthen the national bloodline by expelling foreign-born and nonwhite 'impurities.' In Cuba too, local authorities, protective of slaveholding interests, and hoping to wall the island off from the revolutionary agency of seafarers, began to enforce their own Negro Seamen Act. Recognizing the seafaring community's insurgent capacity, burgeoning nation-states and anxious colonial leaders throughout the Atlantic world began to draw lines and enforce boundaries.[16]

REFORMING THE ATLANTIC WATERFRONT

In attempting to delimit and contain a 'dangerous' free-floating maritime class, states did not act alone. Seafaring communities also increasingly became the objects of interest for reform societies seeking to better, as they saw it, the sailor's condition. Mariners, many complained, led immoral and self-destructive lives, characterized by excessive drinking, sexual licentiousness, and brutal brawling. Taken as a whole, those vices were certainly problematic, but the larger problem again connected to the issue of 'contagion.' For the issue here was exactly that the sailor's dissolute lifestyle might infect and pervert communities throughout the Atlantic where seafarers regularly made landfall. Cleaning up the waterfront would help purify seaport cities, but would also prevent mariners from spreading the 'infection' of depravity as they

circulated among locations throughout the Atlantic. Diplomats and missionaries stationed overseas painted a picture of mariners as, in the words of one evangelist, 'white-faced heathen.' Prone to sickening displays of viciousness, men of the sea needed to be restrained for the good of the entire project of social, economic, religious uplift that was the 'civilizing mission.' Descriptions of seafarers as 'rogues,' 'rascals,' and 'miscreants' peppered more official chatter within the Atlantic world's diplomatic channels, all used to express a growing sense that maritime rambunctiousness demanded containment before more catastrophic damage could be done. Transformation of the sailor's habits, pursued through a variety of methods, became a common answer to the problems presented by an aquatic class of supposedly questionable moral fiber.[17]

And so, during the nineteenth century, waterfront reformers – mostly evangelical Christians inspired by a series of transatlantic religious revivals known as the Second Great Awakening – founded organizations dedicated to the advancement of the sailor's material and spiritual conditions. These were the so-called Bethel Societies. Beginning first in Britain and quickly scattering throughout the Atlantic, ships, churches, and harborside meetinghouses raised the Bethel flag, calling sailors to worship, asking them to renounce their supposedly sinful ways. Meanwhile, associations such as the American Seamen's Friend Society and Port of London Society (later the British Sailors' Society) pressured ship owners and mercantile firms to donate money that would be used to distribute bibles, build churches, erect boarding houses and reading rooms, and establish banks for the benefit of common seamen. Commercial hubs where sailors swarmed became attractive targets for those seeking a solution to what middle-class activists increasingly referred to as the recklessness of the ocean's nautical ambassadors. While typically understood as one part (and a relatively insignificant one when compared to abolition or temperance) of the era's larger reform movements, we might better view these efforts as part of a consequential and coordinated international assault against the threat to the stability of the mercantile economic order posed by mariner misdeeds. Powerful interests aligned behind this crusade, and couched their proposed solution to a perceived crisis in Atlantic capitalism in the language of religious uplift. The steady, sober, spiritually sound habits of businessmen needed to become those of sailors as well.[18]

'Proper' authorities – mostly merchants and their allies in government – the argument went, would be secure in their profits once they had taught mariners the virtues of sobriety and self-respect. This was, of course, a self-interested claim. Drunken and degenerate crews endangered ships and their valuable cargoes, thereby driving up marine insurance rates and the costs of doing business more generally. A concerted effort to instruct seamen to 'behave,' to bring some semblance of discipline to transatlantic waterfront communities more generally, would ensure a more compliant workforce. The secure conduct of trade now depended upon toughening the temperament of the era's largest and most influential class of transnational intermediaries: sailors. With the many 'villainies [that] have been practised' by mariners on his mind, it was, as one U.S. diplomat argued, 'absolutely necessary to retrieve the character of Americans' at his outpost, and presumably, elsewhere. 'Character' – a concept central to reform movements of the long nineteenth century – became a word repeated in diplomatic correspondence, and spoken about as crucial to the commercial contacts which sustained the Atlantic world. Missionaries,

meanwhile, saw in their efforts at sailor conversion a dual advantage: the preservation of valuable economic relations jeopardized by mariner radicalism and disruptiveness, as well as the creation of additional evangelists who would spread the Word as they traveled the world. Reformers divined in the omnipresence of American sailors at all the planet's parts a prophetic possibility. Mariners, 'confined to no place,' men of 'extensive influence,' if brought to Christ, could prove instrumental to 'the spread of truth in the world.' Sailors became itinerant evangelists in a double sense: of the nation, and, given proper exertions, the word of God. As one rapturous waterfront prophet enthused, 'let the seamen of our land be converted…and an influence is brought to bear upon the missionary enterprise which will give it a mighty impulse; the Gospel will have free course and be glorified throughout the world!'[19]

But nor were sailors the sole 'problem.' Harborside districts more generally were often the subject of middle-class suspicion, ire, reformism. The seafaring community consisted not only of sailors working at sea, but their wives, children, and families ashore, all of whom performed much of the labor which allowed Atlantic waterfronts to operate. Women were absolutely crucial actors here, and though life on the open ocean was an almost entirely male pursuit, the era's so-called 'gentler sex' performed a good deal of the rough work which allowed families with husbands, brothers, and sons at sea to scrape by. With men absent, waterfront households, marketplaces, and lives more generally were run overwhelmingly by female entrepreneurs. To make ends meet, women performed piecework spinning yarn and canvas for sails and flags, opened their homes to paid boarders, and operated taverns or brothels. They managed money, property, and made other financial arrangements, thus cultivating a dependency among seafarers upon their partners back home. These were individuals, in short, who did not comport with emerging ideals and standards regarding the 'proper' place of women within society. Bourgeois ideologues might have insisted that the women's sphere remain confined to the household and isolated from the tawdry and hypercompetitive commercial world, but for the waterfront's denizens, such separation of men's and women's roles made little practical sense. Part of the problem with seafaring labor from the reformers' point of view, then, was that it degraded women by forcing them into the sort of independent role in the world for which they were ill-equipped. It turned women into producers of wealth rather than passive, if prudent, consumers. Moreover, they contended, men were supposed to support their dependents; with charities and poor-relief for seafaring families straining city tax revenues, observers pointed to the deficient masculinity of mariners – who failed to provide for their families – as a source of urban disorder and moral decay. Port-city women, however, even if rarely empowered by the assumption of responsibilities otherwise coded 'male,' showed remarkable resourcefulness despite the rampant poverty and broader disapproval surrounding their lives. Many proved scornful of attacks against their character as women who propagated vice and impropriety.[20]

Seafarers themselves were also usually unenthusiastic about reformist agendas considered to be efforts at curtailing their freedom. To be sure, some sailors appreciated waterfront reformers, and took seriously their attempts to save souls and improve conditions afloat and ashore. Mariners, like many other peoples exposed to missionary work throughout the Atlantic world, used evangelism to their own ends, took advantage of what opportunities it presented, and discarded what they disagreed with. Indeed, many sailors were especially supportive of transatlantic campaigns against corporal

punishment at sea; flogging afloat was eventually outlawed in the United States by 1850 and Great Britain by 1879. But, the overall thrust of the historical record suggests that many more men were actively hostile toward maritime improvement organizations. Customary understandings of liberty within the seafaring community placed emphasis upon the very drinking and 'vice' reformers sought to eradicate. The bonds of fraternity among shipmates could potentially be disrupted if the activists' vision triumphed. Most individuals appear to have looked upon the changes as, in the words of one seafarer, 'a new instrument of tyranny.' This was a particularly provocative assessment amongst American sailors, given their sense of themselves as crucial instruments in the republican revolution against oppression. Efforts to curtail their traditional liberties – not considered immoral, but rather, as necessary release after the close confinement of an ocean voyage – were to be met with skepticism if not outrage.[21]

ATLANTIC ANOMIE

But for seafaring communities on the defensive vis-à-vis their customary rights and privileges, the nineteenth century proved a befuddling age throughout the Atlantic. Norms related to the time-honored waterfront conception of liberty began to disintegrate at a rapid rate. This was an era characterized by swift technological and structural change, and maritime peoples at mid century would gaze upon a world transformed. It was difficult, circa 1850, to point to much that was definitively Atlantic about an increasingly globalized industry. The pace of change was different depending upon one's location within the Atlantic world. Large seaports such as London, Liverpool, and New York had begun to transform by the eighteenth century and earlier. Smaller seaports like Salem or Newport experienced definitive alterations over the course of the nineteenth century. But no matter the precise chronology, the results were largely similar: voyages were becoming more capital intensive, labor intensive, and difficult as time progressed.[22]

Seafaring at an earlier moment had, with some important exceptions, been characterized by the basic familiarity of ships' crews with one another and their officers. Men knew their shipmates within the larger context of the local community in which they all resided, and while on the open ocean, crews were governed by long-standing norms within that community. Individuals who went to sea, moreover, did so as a stage in their working lives. They were not, in other words, part of a permanent class of maritime workers, but rather, a collection of young men who had grown up near the sea, and took to the ocean because it was expected of them, and because seafaring was a natural way to make ends meet early in life before settling down ashore. The vast majority of Atlantic voyages were short, coastal excursions which connected places relatively close to one another, and most who labored afloat rarely had occasion to speak of their duties as something out of the ordinary. Today, we are accustomed to think of maritime work as something extraordinary, and sailors as relatively eccentric or exotic persons. But the construction of seafaring communities as fundamentally 'different' or 'distinct' from other places or types of labor was itself a process, a set of ideas with a history of their own.[23]

And that process accelerated rapidly during the nineteenth century, the result of both technological change and the increased volume of transatlantic trade. The burgeoning dimensions of commercial traffic was itself a product of concomitant industrial and market revolutions sweeping across the western hemisphere. Seafaring

labor fed a massive machine comprised of captive African laborers extracting cotton, sugar, and other staples in the Americas, as well as the manufacturing facilities in Europe which processed those commodities. But, as more ships plied the Atlantic, carriers faced stiffer competition. Profit margins significantly narrowed, and premiums were placed on speed, as well as on turnaround in port. In this more rapidly paced economic environment, costs were cut wherever possible in order to preserve a particular shipping firm's competitive advantage. Those saving measures usually impacted common sailors most significantly. So while many basic elements of the seaman's duty – to hand, reef, knot, splice, and steer – remained familiar enough, the context in which they were performed had been transformed. Larger vessels, longer voyages, strange destinations, and different crew composition gave to life afloat in the nineteenth century a flavor quite unlike that of earlier eras.[24]

The faster-paced tempo of nineteenth-century seafaring life is best reflected in the rise of packet ships traversing the Atlantic. In 1817, several New York textile merchants proposed to redefine oceanic shipping by introducing regularly scheduled service between their homeport and Liverpool. The draw was supposed to be speed. Tramp shipping had long moved from port to port in a fairly haphazard way, picking up cargo and ballast at a captain's discretion. Packet service – named for the packets of mail innovators expected to deliver regularly between North America and Europe – promised instead to adhere to defined timetables. Their motive was to secure profit from postal service contracts, passengers, and freight. Their prices came at a premium, but with the promise of speed and dependability. Shifts in shipping technology, pushed by packet companies, made those promises possible. The box-like ships of the seventeenth and eighteenth century were replaced by narrower, sleeker designs capable of carrying more sail and cutting through the water at faster pace. These were the so-called Baltimore clippers, forebears of the famously majestic clipper ships of the 1840s and 1850s, and they sailed as the 'Black Ball Line,' named for the dark spheres painted on their canvas. A new era of rapid transit was inaugurated, further advanced by technological changes. The advent of steam power was gradually, if fitfully, brought to bear on oceanic commerce, which resulted in American entrepreneur Edward Collins and Englishman Samuel Cunard operating several Atlantic steamship lines. The Atlantic world itself was becoming more fast-paced, with an emphasis placed on reliability, timetables, and scheduling.[25]

Yet the thinning profit margins along which highly competitive carriers operated took a real toll on seafarers. Across the nineteenth century, shippers shaved labor costs by skimping on pay, while at the same time, hard-driving captains and 'bucko' mates imposed stricter disciplinary regimes in order to extract more labor from men driven to push vessels across the ocean far faster than ever before. In the aggregate, voyages between 1800–1850 became more arduous, crew sizes were reduced, and real wages shrank. All of this meant, for common sailors, harsher punishment, longer periods of time spent at sea, more labor for each individual while afloat, and all for diminishing compensation. A key element in this new maritime regime was the heterogeneous social composition of nineteenth-century crews. Previously, a ship's complement consisted of people who knew one another, moved in roughly comparable social circles, and only in rare instances, expected to spend their entire working lives at sea. Now, larger and larger numbers of vessels shipped crews composed of men who were strangers to one another, and whose officers were more responsive to

shipping firms than the needs of ordinary seamen. The pressures of the bottom line helped create a more distinct, perpetual, and self-perpetuating class of mariners.[26]

In a word, the nineteenth-century Atlantic seafaring community was experiencing rapid proletarianization. Maritime work was shifting from something one did temporarily to something connoting more permanent status. Upward social mobility within seafaring communities declined precipitously; generally, men became locked into position rather than climbing the ranks. Waterfront districts were increasingly populated by a permanent underclass of shipboard workers trapped in persistent cycles of poverty and debt-dependency. Rather than being dispersed throughout the population, specific urban arenas arose to cater to the needs of impoverished seafarers, while the mercantile elite and a better-paid officer class occupied the healthier, wealthier zones of ever more stratified Atlantic seaport cities. Hence one historian's assertion that the period from 1850 to 1950 was 'the great era of the proletarianized waterfront.' Seafaring was riven by the cleavages of class more than ever before, and shipmasters responded to the risks of employing perennially discontented and underpaid workers by running a tighter ship. And, as the scores of cases before courts sitting in admiralty testify, shipmasters and their officers were much quicker to reinforce their commands with physical abuse. Sailors showed their dissatisfaction by jumping ship; the swift rise in rates of desertion reflects these sweeping changes in seafaring labor.[27]

Voting with one's feet became a popular tactic within the Anglo-American maritime world. The United States and Great Britain still dominated shipping lanes in the Atlantic, but, by the 1850s, British and American citizens abandoned the ocean in large numbers. They turned inward, seeking opportunities in industry ashore, and were replaced by sailors from northern Europe, South Asia, and the Pacific Rim. But it was not only the maritime labor pool which was globalizing at this point in time. The Atlantic basin was becoming less a bounded commercial entity and more a jumping off point for the wider world. Or, that is to say, the commerce of the Atlantic world was integrating more thoroughly into a world system of exchange. These changes, of course, were not all-encompassing. Specialized, localized seafaring populations ended the 1850s looking much the same as they had during the 1800s. Coastal trade networks still flourished and interior waterways were expanded with the reshaping of rivers and the construction of canals. Fishermen still plied the North Atlantic's waters, whaleships continued to thread their way through familiar seas, and colliers still hauled their sooty loads across the North Sea. The sheer diversity of seafaring communities cannot be overstated. But nor can the broader trends shaping those communities be denied. As the volume of trade increased exponentially, waterborne work became more and more sweated. The composition of the labor force in turn shifted. Shipowners from the Atlantic world's principal maritime powers increasingly recruited foreign-born workers to man vessels and subjected those ships to more stringent discipline. Maritime labor, meanwhile, became a much less remunerative occupation. It was now low-status work performed by those individuals thought too 'intemperate,' 'restless,' or 'aimless' to succeed on shore.[28]

Indeed, seafaring was thought the destiny of a 'degraded' and altogether 'different' caste of men exactly because it increasingly looked retrograde within the burgeoning 'free-labor' (or 'freer labor,' at least) markets of industrial capitalism coming to dominate Atlantic seaport cities. Men who labored on ships, by the developing standards of the time, were subject to what was considered an unusual degree of

regulation by public authorities. And, moreover, sailors were still harshly disciplined within their floating workplaces by masters given broad legal authority to maintain order and compel labor. Sailors, therefore, simply looked like something of a breed apart within the capitalist system's growing army of workers. For while a factory worker could, at least in theory, walk away from his job whenever he pleased, a seafarer could be legally obliged to continue serving. Deserting a textile mill was not a crime; deserting a ship, on the other hand, was considered an offense, and the seaman in question could be arrested, jailed, and forced back on board. This made seamen appear as anachronisms, as something closer to a slave or an indentured servant. Seaman Roland Gould thus explained the increasingly anomalous position of seafaring communities within the liberalizing order of the Atlantic world by asking his nineteenth-century readers an easily answerable question: 'What American would ever be content to rivet the chains of slavery upon himself?' The externally coercive and largely patriarchal command structure of seafaring communities were now things to be avoided; Gould's query implied as much. The rigidity of shipboard discipline marked seafaring as odd in a world coming to consensus about the importance of internalized self-discipline – rather than legal and physical coercion – in the maintenance of labor relationships. Fewer men, therefore, chose that watery way of life unless absolutely necessary.[29]

Sailors were no longer celebrated as the bulwark of republican liberty, or the proud keepers of the British empire's wooden walls. They were now alternately pitied and excoriated as a quasi-enslaved class of unfree laborers radically out of step with the modernizing transatlantic basin. In the United States, the free-ranging western settler became the 'stock' national hero, while in Great Britain, the pith-helmeted pioneers of empire attained greater renown than their floating forebears. America turned to the commercial world locked within its own vast territorial empire; its former mother country's interests simply grew to encompass more of the planet's peoples beyond the Atlantic. Meanwhile, those who remained at sea were increasingly thought of by people on shore as strangers, aliens, and exotic. Seafaring communities, which had started the nineteenth century as powerful symbols and important political icons, had become, as Melville complained, the perceived 'refuse and offscourings of the earth.' Beginning at the center of events, the noted novelist implied, mariners were, by the 1850s, now at the periphery; they had, by and large, been 'forgotten.' Crucial actors in helping craft the connective linkages that defined the Atlantic world, seafarers had become a transnational proletariat removed from much of the public's consciousness. They were less 'Atlantic' and more 'global.' Sailors had, in effect, been swallowed whole – reduced to poverty and condemned to anonymity – by the same forces they had helped unleash.

NOTES

1 Herman Melville, *Redburn* (New York: Harper & Brothers, 1849), 178–79.
2 Frank T. Bullen, *The Men of the Merchant Service* (New York: Stokes, 1900), 251–53.
3 Paul Gilje, *Liberty on the Waterfront: American Maritime Culture in the Age of Revolution* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2004), 97–129; Gary Nash, *Urban Crucible: Social Change, Political Consciousness, and the Origins of the American Revolution* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1979).
4 Denver Brunsman, *The Evil Necessity: British Naval Impressment in the Eighteenth-Century Atlantic World* (Charlottesville, VA: University of Virginia Press, 2013).

5 Jesse Lemisch, 'Jack Tar in the Streets: Merchant Seamen in the Politics of Revolutionary America,' *William and Mary Quarterly* 25, No. 3 (July, 1968), 371–407, and quoted 401; Jesse Lemisch, *Jack Tar Versus John Bull: The Role of New York's Seamen in Precipitating the Revolution* (New York: Routledge, 1997); Peter Linebaugh and Marcus Rediker, *The Many-Headed Hydra: Sailors, Slaves, Commoners, and the Hidden History of the Revolutionary Atlantic* (Boston: Beacon Press, 2000), 211–47.

6 Blatchford in Gilje, *Liberty on the Waterfront*, 97–98.

7 Kariann Yokota, *Unbecoming British: How Revolutionary America Became a Postcolonial Nation* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2011), 115–52; Robert J. Allison, *The Crescent Obscured: The United States and the Muslim World, 1776–1815* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1995).

8 Hester Blum, *The View from the Masthead: Maritime Imagination and Antebellum American Sea Narratives* (Chapel Hill: UNC Press, 2008), 46–70; Lawrence Peskin, *Captives and Countrymen: Barbary Slavery and the American Public, 1785–1816* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2009); 'Brave republicans of the ocean' in Gilje, *Liberty on the Waterfront*, 130–62.

9 Gilje, *Liberty on the Waterfront*, 163–91.

10 Paul Gilje, *Free Trade and Sailors' Rights in the War of 1812* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013); Troy Bickham, *The Weight of Vengeance: The United States, the British Empire, and the War of 1812* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2012), 20–48.

11 Marcus Rediker, *Villains of All Nations: Atlantic Pirates in the Golden Age* (Boston: Beacon Press, 2004); Kris E. Lane, *Pillaging the Empire: Piracy in the Americas, 1500–1750* (Armonk, N.Y.: M.E. Sharpe, 1998); Robert C. Ritchie, *Captain Kidd and the War Against the Pirates* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1986).

12 N.A.M. Rodger, *The Wooden World: An Anatomy of the Georgian Navy* (New York: W.W. Norton, 1996); James Dugan, *The Great Mutiny* (New York, 1965).

13 Julius Scott, 'Afro-American Sailors and the International Communication Network,' in Howell and Twomey, eds., *Jack Tar in History: Essays in the History of Maritime Life and Labour* (Fredericton, New Brunswick: Acadiensis Press, 1991), 37–52; W. Jeffrey Bolster, *Black Jacks: African American Seamen in the Age of Sail* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1997); David S. Cecelski, *The Waterman's Song: Slavery and Freedom in Maritime North Carolina* (Chapel Hill: UNC Press, 2001), quoted p. 28.

14 Bolster, *Black Jacks*; Cecelski, *Waterman's Song*; Paul Gilroy, *The Black Atlantic: Modernity and Double Consciousness* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1993). Frederick Douglass, *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass* (London: H.G. Collins, 1851), 61.

15 Bolster, *Black Jacks*, 200–214 and Leon Fink, *Sweatshops at Sea: Merchant Seamen in the World's First Globalized Industry, from 1812 to the Present* (Chapel Hill: UNC Press, 2011), 50–55; Michael Schoeppner, 'Navigating the Dangerous Atlantic: Racial Quarantines, Black Sailors, and United States Constitutionalism,' (Ph.D. Diss., University of Florida, 2010), passim, and quoted, p. 69.

16 Isaac Land, 'Bread and Arsenic: Citizenship from the Bottom Up in Georgian London,' *Journal of Social History* 39, No. 1 (Fall 2005), 89–110 and Land, *War, Nationalism, and the British Sailor, 1750–1850* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2009). On Cuba, see Schoeppner, 'Navigating the Dangerous Atlantic,' 188–213.

17 *Berkshire County Whig*, Vol. 1, Issue 42, Dec. 23, 1841. The best treatment of waterfront reform movements appears in Gilje, *Liberty on the Waterfront*, 195–227.

18 Gilje, *Liberty on the Waterfront*, 195–227. The more general spirit of reform is covered in Bruce Dorsey, *Reforming Men and Women: Gender in the Antebellum City* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell, 2002). Valerie Burton argues that reformers propagated the stereotype of the rowdy sailor as a foil to the sort of workers – soberly inclined, fastidious – they hoped to raise within Britain and the U.S. in '"Whoring, Drinking Sailors": Reflections on

Masculinity from the Labour History of Nineteenth-Century British Shipping,' in Margaret Walsh, ed., *Working Out Gender: Perspectives from Labour History* (London: Ashgate, 1999), 84–101. Stereotypes about sailors, then, tell us next to nothing about maritime lives, but rather speak to the imperatives of capitalist development ashore.

19 RG 59, M101, Consular Despatches from Canton, China, Reel One, letter dated May 11, 1795; *The Sailor's Magazine and Naval Journal*, Vol. 5, No. 1 (Sept., 1832), 1–2 and New Bedford Port Society quoted in ibid., 15; 'Communications and Selections: The Shipmaster' in *Sailor's Magazine and Naval Journal* Vol. 8, No. 1 (Sept. 1835), 9; 'When Shall the World be Converted Unto God?' in *The Sailor's Magazine and Naval Journal* Vol. 7, No. 67 (March, 1834), 204–5; 'Who Prays for the Conversion of Seamen?' in *The Sailor's Magazine and Naval Journal* Vol. 7, No. 75 (Nov., 1834), 67. As Isaac Land argues in *War, Nationalism, and the British Sailor*, 77: 'Jack Tar ruled the waves, but until he could master himself, he would remain a suspect figure.' Broader importance of 'character' to nineteenth-century reformers is seen in James Salazar, *Bodies of Reform: The Rhetoric of Character in Gilded Age America* (New York: NYU Press, 2010).

20 The lives of women in port in Seth Rockman, *Scraping By: Wage Labor, Slavery, and Survival in Early Baltimore* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2009); Ellen Hartigan-O'Connor, *The Ties That Buy: Women and Commerce in Revolutionary America* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2009); Elaine Forman Crane, *Ebb Tide in New England: Women, Seaports, and Social Change, 1630–1800* (Boston: Northeastern University Press, 1998); Lisa Norling, *Captain Ahab Had a Wife: New England Women and the Whalefishery, 1720–1870* (Chapel Hill: UNC Press, 2000).

21 Gilje, *Liberty on the Waterfront*, 195–227, quoted 221; Myra C. Glenn, *Campaigns Against Corporal Punishment: Prisoners, Sailors, Women, and Children in Antebellum America* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1984); Margarent Creighton, *Rites and Passages: The Experience of American Whaling, 1830–1870* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995).

22 Daniel Vickers, *Young Men and the Sea: Yankee Seafarers in the Age of Sail* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 2005).

23 Vickers, *Young Men and the Sea*, 163–213.

24 Ibid.

25 Alex Roland, W. Jeffrey Bolster, and Alexander Keyssar, *The Way of the Ship: America's Maritime History Reenvisioned, 1600–2000* (Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley and Sons, 2008), 158–71.

26 Vickers, *Young Men and the Sea*, 163–213.

27 'Proletarianization' of deep-sea labor in Marcus Rediker, *Between the Devil and the Deep Blue Sea: Merchant Seamen, Pirates, and the Anglo-American Maritime World, 1700–1750* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987); Linebaugh and Rediker, *Many-Headed Hydra*; Vickers, *Young Men and the Sea*, 248–51; John R. Gillis, *The Human Shore: Seacoasts in History* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2012), 112–13, who refers to the period from 1850–1950 as the 'great era of the proletarianized waterfront.'

28 Emphasis on coastal and interior waterways in Roland, Bolster, and Keyssar, *Way of the Ship*. Fisheries are discussed in Christopher P. Magra, *The Fisherman's Cause: Atlantic Commerce and the Maritime Dimensions of the American Revolution* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2009) and W. Jeffrey Bolster, *The Mortal Sea: Fishing the Atlantic in the Age of Sail* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 2012).

29 Vickers, *Young Men and the Sea*, 214–47; Roland Gould, *The Life of Gould, An Ex-Man-of-War's-Man; With Incidents on Sea and Shore, Including a Three-Year's Cruise on the Line of Battle Ship* Ohio, *on the Mediterranean Station, Under the Veteran Commodore Hall* (Claremont, N.H.: Claremont Manufacturing Company, 1867), 191.